MISS PELL'S CASE OF THE WEEK · NO. 1

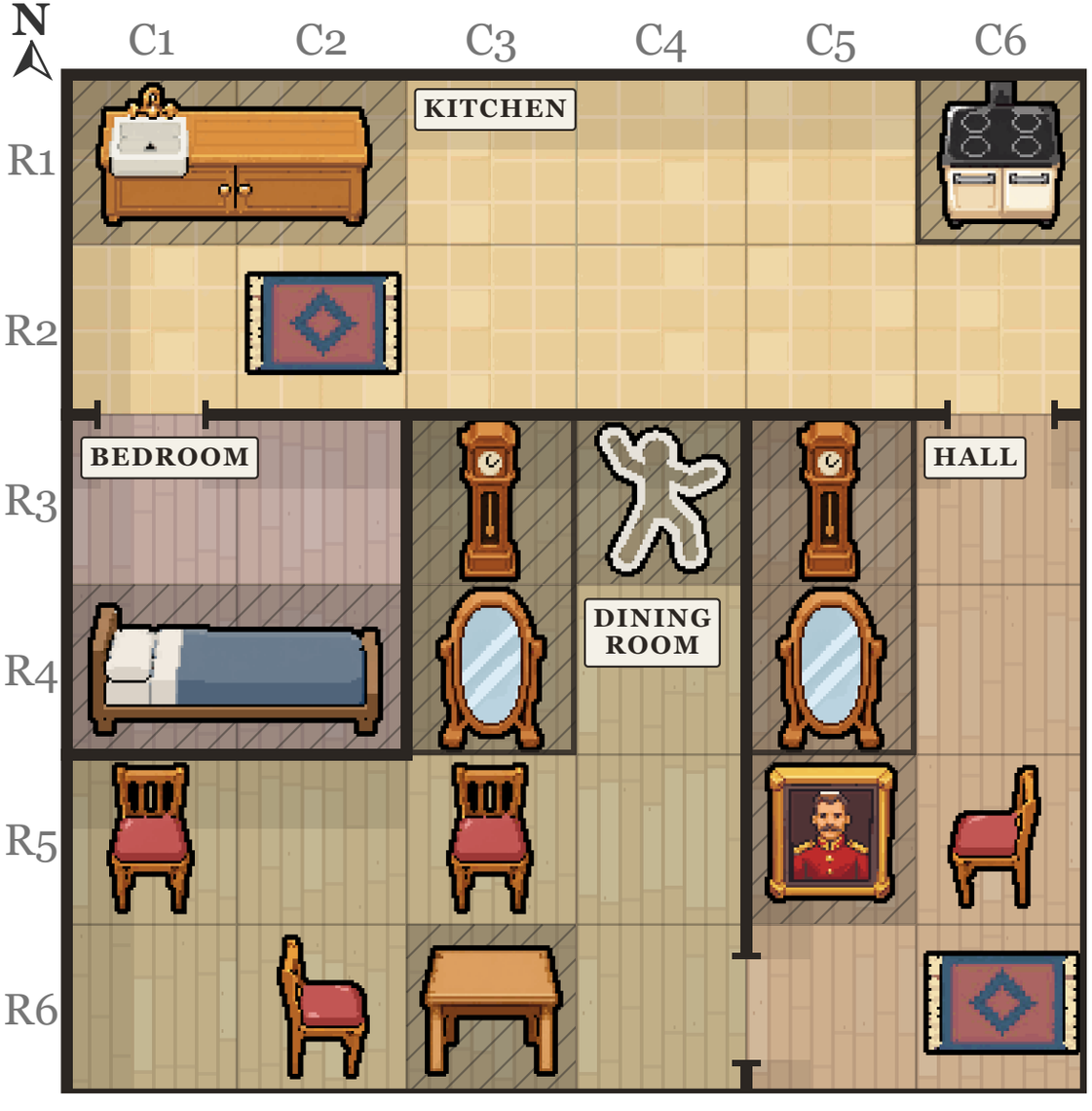
The Answer: The Empty Chair

Here is the case again, and then its answer one deduction at a time, with a picture of the plan after each step. In the pictures, **yellow** squares are where the suspect in question could still be, **red crosses** are what that step has just ruled out, and **initials** mark suspects already placed.

The Empty Chair

GENTLE

SOLVED STEP BY STEP ON THE FOLLOWING PAGES



A wet October evening, with rain on every window. When the lamps came back on, Harold lay in the Dining Room, and nobody had moved an inch.

THE CLUES

1. Olive was not beside a rug.
2. Agatha was in an area with no mirrors.
3. Edith was in the fifth column.
4. Sam was not beside a chair.
5. Nora was in an area with no portraits.
6. Lucy was in the top row.

GENERAL CLUES

7. Of the people beside a sink, exactly two wore a bowler.

THE SUSPECTS

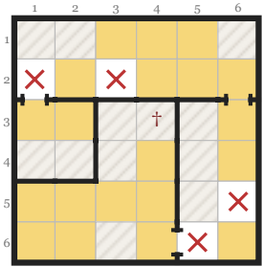


1. Lucy
   a bowler
   spectacles
2. Edith
   a fedora
   a monocle
3. Olive
   a bowler
   a monocle
4. Nora
   a fedora
   a monocle
5. Agatha
   a fedora
   spectacles
6. Sam
   a monocle
   a beard

THE MURDERER

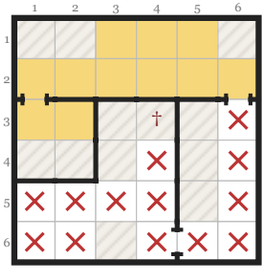
_____

The answer, step by step

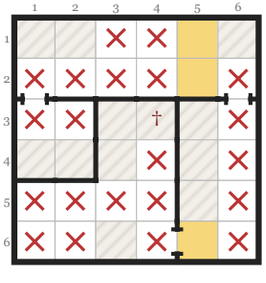


1 Clue 1: Olive has 20 squares left.

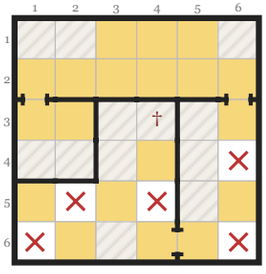
> **Ruling out.** A statement that says where a guest was not is still a statement: cross those squares off.



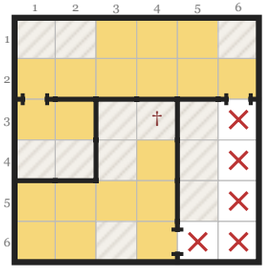
2 Clue 2: Agatha has 11 squares left.



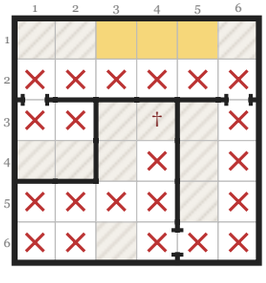
3 Clue 3: Edith must be somewhere in column 5.



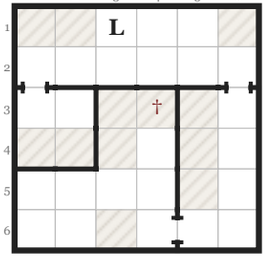
4 Clue 4: Sam has 19 squares left.



5 Clue 5: Nora has 19 squares left.

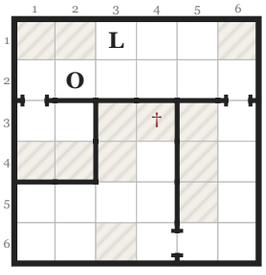


6 Clue 6: Lucy must be somewhere in row 1.



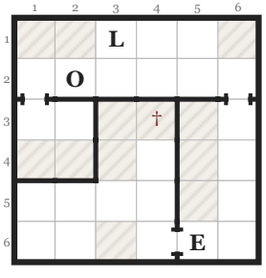
7 Clue 7 settles it: Lucy is at R1C3.

> **What they wore.** Statements about hats, spectacles, monocles and beards refer to the lineup. Work out who they can be about first, then where.

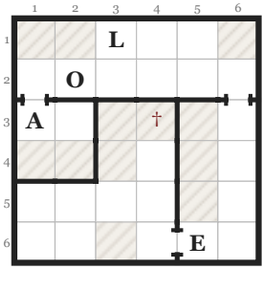


8 Olive has only one square left: R2C2.

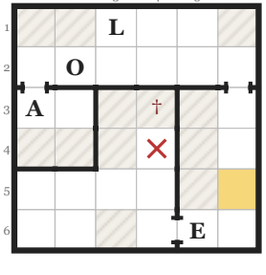
> **One square left.** When everything else has been ruled out for a guest, the square that remains is theirs.



9 Edith has only one square left: R6C5.

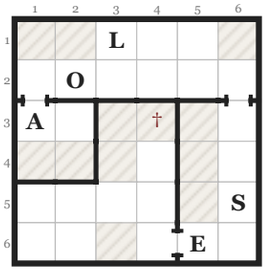


10 Agatha has only one square left: R3C1.

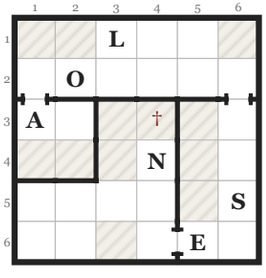


11 Sam is the only suspect who can still stand in column 6, so they must be somewhere in it.

> **The only one who fits.** Every row and column must hold exactly one guest. If only one guest can still stand anywhere in a line, they must stand there.



12 Sam has only one square left: R5C6.



13 Only one square is left for Nora, so Nora is at R4C4.

With the grid full, only Nora was in the Dining Room with Harold. Nora is the murderer.

The next case

Every Friday, Miss Pell posts a new case at **whereaboutspuzzles.com**. Fifty more are in her ledger, **Whereabouts: Murder Sudoku — 50 Murder Mysteries from Ashcombe Manor**, from spring to winter.